

loyal to Lincoln felt they could not win unless they joined with “War Democrats,” who were crossing the party line to disassociate themselves from the Copperheads. The result was called the National Union Party, and it convened in Baltimore during early June. Lincoln was renominated, but Vice President Hannibal Hamlin, a Radical Republican, was dropped from the ticket. He was replaced by Andrew Johnson, military governor of Tennessee and a leading War Democrat. The National Unionists hoped the new ticket would underscore the national character of the war.

COPPERHEADS Those Northerners opposed to war with the Confederacy, named for a poisonous snake. They were most numerous in the Ohio River states, with traditional ties to the South.

Esteem for McClellan

Meanwhile, Lincoln sensed that defeat was imminent. Grant’s strategy was failing. The death toll at the Wilderness, Spotsylvania, and Cold Harbor had staggered the nation—and still Lee held Grant at bay at Petersburg. General Jubal Early, with but 10,000 Rebels, had threatened to walk into the White House. Widespread discouragement was starting to swell the ranks of the Copperheads. General George B. McClellan, fired by Lincoln in 1862, was riding high in public estimation; as the fatalities mounted he looked ever more attractive as the man to bring the fighting to an end in a manner that would satisfy both South and North.

In August, the Democrats held a convention in Chicago. They, too, were divided over the war. The more moderate Peace Democrats advocated a negotiated peace on terms favorable to the Union, while the Copperheads declared the war a fiasco that should be immediately terminated. The convention sought to bridge the divide by nominating McClellan, a pro-war moderate, while adopting a sweeping peace platform—which McClellan deplored.